

KENINGFORD PARTNERS

CAPITAL ADVISORY

FOUNDER RESOURCE

Fundraising Timeline

A week-by-week roadmap aligned to a 14-week institutional growth-round cycle, from readiness through close.

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The median institutional growth round now closes in roughly fourteen weeks, nearly double the cycle of the easy-capital window. This roadmap maps the full cycle week by week, including the four preparation weeks before launch that determine how the remaining fourteen unfold. Treat the timeline as a base case: well-prepared processes compress it, and unprepared ones extend it.

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How to Read This Timeline

Weeks are numbered from the first investor meeting. Negative weeks are preparation. Each phase lists the work that must be complete by the end of the window; slippage in any phase pushes the close date roughly one-for-one, so runway planning should assume the full cycle plus a thirty percent buffer.

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Weeks " 4 to 0: Readiness

The highest-leverage period in the entire cycle. Three workstreams run in parallel and all three must finish before the first meeting.

- Build the data room in investor-priority order: cohort economics first, then monthly P&L reconciled to budget, concentration analysis, and preference math under three exit scenarios.
- Map twenty-five to forty prospects at the partner level, not the firm level; know each partner's board seats, check size, and lead follow-on record.
- Calibrate the narrative around structural readiness: why this amount, why now, and what the capital makes true in eighteen months.
- Pressure-test the model in a dry run with a friendly investor or advisor before any live meeting.

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Weeks 1–3: Outreach and First Meetings

- Launch sequenced outreach in two or three waves, prioritized by fit rather than breadth; keep the first wave small enough to iterate.

- Hold first management meetings and log every question asked; recurring questions are diligence themes, one-off questions are noise.
- Update materials on pattern feedback only. Rewriting the deck after every meeting signals uncertainty.
- Hold second-wave outreach until the narrative has stabilized against first-wave feedback.

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Weeks 4–8: Deep Diligence and Competitive Tension

- Run a controlled Q&A process: one intake channel, forty-eight-hour response standard, and a living FAQ so answers stay consistent across investors.
- Keep the data room current; a stale data room mid-process reads as a company losing control of its numbers.
- Maintain parallel conversations so no single counterparty controls the clock; sequencing intent matters more than volume.
- Prepare management to discuss unit economics and capital priorities without slides; partner-level conviction is built in unscripted exchanges.

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Weeks 9–11: Term Sheets and Structure

- Compare offers on structure, not headline valuation: model participation, pro-rata, and anti-dilution effects across at least three exit scenarios.
- A four percent valuation premium can cost five to seven points of founder dilution at exit once structure is modeled; do the math before choosing a lead.
- Reference-check the lead partner with founders from their existing portfolio, including at least one company that underperformed.
- Negotiate the term sheet fully before signing; economics agreed at term sheet rarely improve in documentation.

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Weeks 12–14: Confirmatory Diligence and Close

- Grant exclusivity only when terms, syndicate, and process confidence justify shutting down the alternatives.
- Complete confirmatory diligence, definitive documentation, and closing conditions with counsel driving a dated checklist.
- Track every closing condition to a named owner and a date; unowned conditions are where closings slip.
- Plan communications for close: employees, existing investors, and customers hear it from you, not from the press release.

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Runway Math

A fourteen-week cycle plus a thirty percent buffer is roughly eighteen weeks, call it four and a half months from first meeting to funds wired. Add the four preparation weeks and the honest planning number is close to six months. If current runway cannot support six months plus two quarters of post-close operating cushion, size a bridge to the readiness work it funds, not as a pre-emption of the round itself.

NEXT STEP

Put this to work with our team

This resource is part of the Keningford Partners founder toolkit. If you are preparing for a capital raise, sale process, or board decision, our team will review your materials against this framework and tell you where the gaps are, at no cost.

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